

From a Rockabilly Surprise to a Life-Changing Hit: The Wild History of World Cup Anthems

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Picture this: It's 1962 in Chile. The World Cup is about to start, and a local rock band called Los Ramblers decides to record a peppy, **rockabilly** tune to fire up the national team. FIFA didn't commission it. Nobody asked them to. But 'El Rock del Mundial' became an instant smash across South America and it planted a seed. That unofficial anthem showed soccer's governing body that a great song could become as crucial to the tournament as a last-minute goal. Fast-forward to today, and official World Cup anthems are a global phenomenon. Some are inescapable **earworms**; others fade into obscurity. With the 2026 tournament underway, we dove into every official FIFA song since 1990 to spotlight the bops that defined eras and the deep cuts you might have missed. Let's start with the queen of them all: Shakira's 'Waka Waka (This Time for Africa).' Released for the 2010 South Africa World Cup, it fused Afro-Colombian rhythms with South African styles and became a cultural juggernaut. You didn't need to watch a single match to know every word. In 2024, it was crowned the most-streamed World Cup song ever and snagged a Guinness World Record. But for Shakira, the impact was deeply personal. 'It's one of my biggest songs of all time,' she said. 'But beyond what it did for my music and career... it turned me into my mother.' On the video set, she met footballer Gerard Piqué, the father of her two children. Talk about a life-changing chorus. Not every anthem hits those heights, but many are fascinating time capsules. In 2006, classical **crossover** group Il Divo and R&B icon Toni Braxton ditched the usual hype for a sweeping ballad, 'The Time of Our Lives,' **crooning** about 'the glory and the pain' over a swelling orchestra. In 2014, Pitbull, Jennifer Lopez, and Brazilian singer Claudia Leitte delivered 'We Are One (Ole Ola),' a track that felt more like a mid-2010s club **banger** than a stadium chant fun, but maybe not timeless. Meanwhile, 'Dar um Jeito (We Will Find a Way)' from the same year blended rock, EDM, and samba with Carlos Santana, Wyclef Jean, and Avicii, featuring lyrics aimed at underprivileged kids: 'Ain't no mountain you can't reach / Grab a star and make a wish.' The 2022 Qatar anthem 'Hayya Hayya' (Arabic for 'let's go') packed Afrobeat and Middle Eastern flavors, uniting American singer Trinidad Cardona, Nigerian star Davido, and Qatari singer Aisha. And way back in 1994, when the U.S. last hosted, Daryl Hall channeled 'The Battle Hymn of the Republic' for the gospel-choir-backed 'Gloryland' because nothing says American patriotism like Hall & Oates meets the Civil War. These songs remind us that the World Cup isn't just about who lifts the trophy. It's about the soundtrack that makes a billion hearts beat together.

Word Treasure

rockabilly -- A style of music that mixes early rock and roll with country twang, popular in the 1950s.

commissioned -- When an organization officially pays for a piece of work to be made, like a song or a painting.

earworms -- Songs that get stuck in your head and you keep humming them over and over.

crossover -- A style of music or art that blends different genres or appeals to multiple

different audiences.

crooning -- Singing softly in a smooth, emotional way, often with a gentle, romantic tone.

banger -- A high-energy song, especially in dance or club music, that makes people want to move.

Background you need

FIFA, the global governing body for soccer, officially started commissioning World Cup songs in 1990 with 'Un'estate italiana' for the Italy tournament. Before that, teams and fans often created their own anthems, like the song 'Three Lions' that English fans still sing today. The very first World Cup was held in 1930 in Uruguay, but catchy, worldwide anthems didn't become a tradition until decades later. A song can travel far beyond the stadiums--Shakira's 'Waka Waka' sold millions and was performed at the closing ceremony in front of 84,000 fans.

The 1962 song by Los Ramblers (a Chilean rock band that formed in the late 1950s) was a surprise hit across South America and showed FIFA that music could become a huge part of the tournament's identity. Fast-forward to the 2026 World Cup, co-hosted by the United States, Canada, and Mexico (the first time three nations share the tournament), and the anthems will likely blend even more cultures.

Break it down

LEAD: A 1962 rockabilly surprise by Los Ramblers showed FIFA that a song could become as vital as a goal.

KEY EVENT: The evolution of official World Cup anthems from an afterthought to a global phenomenon.

+ - DEFINING ANTHEM: Shakira's 'Waka Waka (This Time for Africa)'-- the most-streamed World Cup song ever, blending Afro-Colombian and South African styles, and changing the singer's personal life.

+ - NOTABLE OTHERS:

| +- 2006: Il Divo and Toni Braxton's sweeping orchestral ballad 'The Time of Our Lives'.

| +- 2014: Pitbull, J.Lo, and Claudia Leitte's club banger 'We Are One (Ole Ola)'.

| +- 2014: 'Dar um Jeito' with Santana, Wyclef, and Avicii -- a mix of rock, EDM, and samba for underprivileged kids.

| +- 2022: 'Hayya Hayya' fusing Afrobeat and Middle Eastern flavors.

| +- 1994: Daryl Hall's patriotic 'Gloryland' with a gospel choir.

+ - CONCLUSION: The World Cup isn't just about lifting the trophy--it's about the soundtrack that makes a billion hearts beat together.

Why it matters

These songs aren't just background noise--they shape how you remember a whole summer, turning a sports tournament into a shared cultural moment. Even ten years later, hearing one can take you right back to the excitement and connect you with millions of other fans your age around the world.

Test what you remember

1. Which song is considered the first unofficial World Cup anthem, recorded by Los Ramblers in 1962?
 - (A) 'Gloryland'
 - (B) 'Waka Waka (This Time for Africa)'
 - (C) 'El Rock del Mundial'
 - (D) 'Hayya Hayya'
2. Shakira's 'Waka Waka' was the official anthem for which World Cup?
 - (A) 2014 Brazil
 - (B) 2006 Germany
 - (C) 2010 South Africa
 - (D) 2022 Qatar
3. What unexpected record did Shakira's 'Waka Waka' achieve by 2024?
 - (A) Most expensive music video
 - (B) Most-streamed World Cup song ever
 - (C) Longest-running number one song
 - (D) First song to win an Oscar
4. The 2014 anthem 'Dar um Jeito (We Will Find a Way)' featured lyrics aimed at which group?
 - (A) Soccer players
 - (B) Underprivileged kids
 - (C) FIFA officials
 - (D) Pop music fans
5. What does the Arabic phrase 'Hayya Hayya', the title of the 2022 Qatar anthem, mean?
 - (A) 'Goal! Goal!'
 - (B) 'Peace and love'
 - (C) 'Let's go'
 - (D) 'Champion's dream'
6. Which American singer performed the 1994 World Cup anthem 'Gloryland', backed by a gospel choir?
 - (A) Pitbull
 - (B) Daryl Hall
 - (C) Wyclef Jean
 - (D) Carlos Santana

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Cultural celebration and artist breakthrough: A hit anthem can launch an artist into global stardom, like Shakira's 'Waka Waka' did, and showcases the host country's culture. Fans and players both get a song that becomes the emotional glue of the tournament.

2. **Commercial and formulaic criticism:** Some anthems feel like they were manufactured by record labels just to sell, lacking genuine passion. Critics argue that when every song follows the same pop or EDM template, it waters down the unique spirit of each World Cup.

3. Time capsule of music trends: Looking back, each official song is a snapshot of what music sounded like in that era--orchestral ballads in 2006, EDM-club fusion in 2014, Afrobeat and Arabic influences in 2022. They mirror the changing global music scene.

4. Future of collaborative anthems: With technology making collaborations across continents easier, future anthems might be written by a collective of artists from all host nations simultaneously. The 2026 World Cup, co-hosted by three countries, could set a new standard for blending languages and genres into one track that truly represents a united world.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):